Honest/Clean

By Carlos Andres Gomez

(NOTE: This "teaser" intro is from the book by Gomez, (ending of Chapter 5), although is not part of the poem itself.

Dr. King and Gandhi were both men. They were both human. They were both flawed. They were both, at times, crippled and haunted by their uncompromising visions of how this life should be lived. Two men with extraordinary ideas about this world, and many of the same flaws, struggles, and compulsions with which we all wrestle. And it is okay to struggle – that is human – but it doesn't mean our ideas or actions have to be anything less than extraordinary.

INTRODUCTION

Joseph Hatcher, a soldier in the 1st Infantry Division of the U.S. Army who did a tour of duty in Iraq in 2004-2005, experienced the struggle of war, politics and ideals first hand. He said: "I love it. I love the fight. It's just I don't think we should be fighting in that country. I don't think we should be fighting a war there for any reason whatsoever.

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But when it actually happens, for those few brief seconds it's – it's honest, it's clean. There's no politics involved when it actually happens." Honest? Clean? What values in our society can even link war and those two words in the same breath?

The poetry of Carolos Andres Gomez questions the concept of aggression both in war and in everyday life. Why does the world value the ability to fight more than the ability to love? And in the tradition of the peaceful protests of Gandhi and Dr. Martin Luther King: Cries out . . . "Let me be . . . .greater than the flawed society in which I live . . . let me be . . . .greater than the flaws within."

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let me be
a mold of soft foam
inside reinforced silicone

let me be
a soggy piece of plywood
nailed across another

let me be
a 50 cm scrap
of folded cotton fabric

an inch and a half
of worn brown leather

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a simple grip of two plates
of poplar wood or stainless steel
something made to hold
someone
or be held
or worshipped
and nothing else

encase me in iron
feed me fuel and gunpowder
make me machine sharp
fingerprint me cutting edge
a smart bomb
a docile land mine

not this vicious human need
don't make me this clouded, raw heart
all conflict and contradiction
all horror and beauty

let me be
a mold of soft foam
inside reinforced silicone

but not the upper arm
attached to it
not the soldier saluting

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above the flag-encased coffin
of his best friend
don't call me prosthesis
as the ghost arm salutes
against his right temple

let me be
a soggy piece of plywood
nailed across another

not a cross
fitted with crude nails and screws
not a symbol of religion or belief
not lighter fluid ignited with a blow torch
not the man shouting to a gathered group
not the pale sheet hiding his cleft palate scar
the nightmares of his alcoholic father
the torment of poverty in Neshoba County, Mississippi
not the stutter he found hate to overcome

let me be
a 50 cm scrap
of folded cotton fabric

let my color be incidental
neither signifier nor signified
neither red nor blue

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neither Athens Park blood
nor Eastside Crip
not the symbol of family
a fatherless son finds
not the tears he hides
the hands he once used
for break-dancing and poems

let me be
an inch and a half
of worn brown leather

not a belt lashing
a little girl's face
not the father holding it
not those nightmares of his father
holding his little boy's hand in scalding hot water
for forgetting his backpack in 4th grade
not the 41-year-old man
that still wets his bed
is still afraid of the dark

let me be
simple
a simple grip of two plates
of poplar wood or stainless steel
attached to a large blade

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or a heavy clip of steel tipped rounds
but not the hand
hewing the sugarcane
hacking up a neighbor
the shaking finger about to fire
a woman dressed in a black hijab
in the scope
about to pull a white flag
from her shopping bag
as the 2nd bullet exits
her 4th vertebra

let me be
absolute

that woman's final breath
a heavy release from the heavens
flood rain like sobbing
a god
that never has to answer
for itself

I want to die an idea
a desperate myth in the sky

as the whole world kneels
not sure

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if this is their last day
on earth --

SOURCE INFORMATION

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